

Improving awareness of non-speech sounds

Why is this important?

Helping children to be more aware of sounds they can hear around them is the first step in building foundation skills for listening to sounds in words.

Learning to tell the difference between sounds is a really important skill and will help with later speech sound development and also literacy skills. Below are some early sound awareness activities for you to try.



Sound versus no sound



Collect a selection of items from your home, some that make a noise such as a squeaky toy or shakers and others that do not such as a book or sock. Put these in a bag. On one piece of paper draw a tick and on another piece draw a cross. Ask your child to take an item out of the bag and ask them if it makes a sound or not. If it makes a sound put the item on the paper with a tick and if not place the item on the paper with the cross.

What's that noise?



Use something which makes a noise e.g. a ticking clock, musical box or your phone. Hide the object in the room and encourage your child to listen for the noise and find the object.

Listen to everyday sounds

When out and about encourage your child to listen out for sounds around them. Go on a listening walk and ask your child to identify the sounds they can hear e.g. bus, car, train, birds etc. Talk about the sounds they hear – are they noisy or quiet? Complete a listening walk tick chart whilst on your walk.



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Listening Lotto



Encourage your child to match the animal or environmental sound to the picture. You can make the sound or find sound recordings on the internet. Using pictures, encourage your child to put a counter on the picture they heard.

Matching musical instruments



For this you will need a set of matching musical instruments or sound makers. One set will be hidden in a bag and the other placed in front of the child. You play one of the musical instruments in the bag. Ask your child to identify which musical instrument they heard. If they cannot find it, try showing them the instrument you are playing first and then see if later they can identify it just by listening.

Make it harder: Try playing two musical instruments together. Can your child identify them and in the correct order?

Actions to sounds



Choose two sounds e.g. clapping and shaker. Decide on two actions such as running or jumping. Explain to your child that when they hear clapping they have to run. When they hear the shaker they must jump.

Make it harder: Try three sounds with matching actions

Long and short sounds



Choose a musical instrument that you can play for a long or short time, for example a tambourine or shaker. If it's a long sound encourage the child to stretch up tall. If it's a short sound encourage the child to curl up as small as they can.



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Loud and quiet sounds



Introduce a sound maker such as a shaker or drum. If you don't have these create loud and quiet sounds with objects from around the house. Demonstrate the sound maker being played loudly and then softly. When your child hears a loud sound encourage your child to walk in the style of the sound e.g. stomp around for a loud sound and tiptoe for a quiet sound

Fast and slow sounds



Using a sound maker such as a drum or using objects from around the house, play it fast and slow. When your child hears a fast sound they run, when they hear a slow sound they move slowly.

Useful books and websites

Listening skills - BBC Teach

<https://www.bbc.co.uk/teach/school-radio/eyfs-listening-skills/zbc4y9q>

Please follow this link for a fantastic collection of audio games of everyday sounds.

Speaking and Listening Activities for the Early Years Book

<https://www.amazon.co.uk/Speaking-Listening-Activities-Early-Years/dp/1783171235>

Speech and Language UK

<https://speechandlanguage.org.uk/educators-and-professionals/>

